

What makes people hostile to immigration?

Introduction

Immigration continues to be one of the most prominent issues in British politics. Immigration has created a fear in some that their country is being ‘invaded’ or that their culture is under threat. Politicians have exploited these fears. For example, Brexiters used slogans such as ‘Take Back Control’ to create fears of unchecked immigration. Support for the Leave outcome in the Brexit referendum was associated with the desire to restore control over immigration.

Reform UK is a populist radical right party which opposes immigration. The party centred their manifesto and much of their policy on immigration. For example, in 2017, their manifesto introduced a net migration target of zero in five years. Reform UK mobilised public anxieties about immigration, linking them to concerns about national identity and sovereignty. For example, the ‘Breaking Point’ poster was a highly controversial campaign billboard unveiled by Nigel Farage, the leader of the party, on June 16, 2016. Farage argued that immigration could not be controlled as long as Britain remained in the European Union (EU). He often spoke about perceived economic and cultural threats from EU migrant workers.¹ People may view immigration negatively because they fear that their jobs are being taken.

This essay examines what makes people hostile to immigration, in particular testing whether hostility is better explained by cultural backlash or by economic concerns. I argue that hostility is primarily driven by cultural causes rather than economic ones.

Definitions

Immigration refers to people moving from one country to another to live there permanently. Hostility to immigration refers to negative attitudes towards immigrants. Immigration can be seen by some as harmful to the economy, culture, or society in general.

The data comes from the UK sample of the 2018 European Social Survey (ESS). The ESS is a cross-country survey conducted every two years. The survey measures public perceptions of immigration, including whether immigrants are good or bad for the country’s economy and whether they enrich or undermine cultural life. These measures allow us to distinguish between economic and cultural causes of hostility to immigration. The survey also includes questions on attitudes towards immigrants from different racial and ethnic groups. This allows us to compare attitudes towards different types of immigration.

¹ Dennison, J., Goodwin, M. 2015. Immigration, Issue Ownership and the Rise of UKIP. Parliamentary Affairs, 68(1), pp.168–187.

Argument

There are two prominent explanations of hostility to immigration. This essay argues that hostility to immigration is primarily explained by cultural rather than economic concerns. Fears about a loss of cultural identity provide a better explanation for immigration attitudes than concerns about economic competition. The cultural explanation focuses on symbolic concerns about national identity, values, and social change. This explanation suggests hostility is driven by perceived cultural threats. Hostility to immigration may be strongest when previously dominant groups feel threatened by value shifts in public opinion. The cultural explanation implies that right-wingers, older people, and those with lower levels of education should be more hostile to immigration because they are more likely to perceive cultural change as a threat.

This is consistent with Norris and Inglehart (2019) who explain Brexit, Trump's election, and the rise of authoritarian populism using their cultural backlash theory. Hostility to immigration has contributed to the popularity of the Leave campaign, Trump, and authoritarian populism. This suggests that the cultural backlash theory may explain attitudes towards immigration. The theory argues that those most likely to have negative attitudes towards immigration are older, less-educated Britons from lower classes. This is because generational, educational, gender, and urban transformations contributed to a value change. For example, increasing education levels shifted attitudes in a more socially liberal direction. This led to the silent revolution in cultural values in a more socially liberal direction. These values are associated with positive attitudes towards immigration. The silent revolution was perceived as a threat to social conservatives' values, triggering a conservative backlash. This was accelerated by economic conditions and rapid growth in social diversity. Indeed, large numbers of immigrants can trigger feelings of threat because people feel that their culture is being changed.

In contrast, the economic threat hypothesis states that hostility is caused by concerns about the impact of immigration on jobs, wages, and benefits.² Competition over scarce resources and threats to material well-being cause hostility to immigration. This is consistent with evidence that opposition to immigration is higher among lower-income people and less-skilled workers.

Furthermore, immigrants who differ from the majority of the population in the colour of their skin, religion, or language tend to be perceived as more threatening. This suggests that hostility is often directed towards 'outsiders', and thus should be stronger towards immigrants from different racial and ethnic groups. Nativism contributes to hostility to immigration. This ideology claims that states should be inhabited only by members of the native group and that non-natives represent a threat to the homogeneous nation-state.³

² Citrin, J., Green, D.P., Muste, C. and Wong, C. (1997). Public Opinion Toward Immigration Reform: The Role of Economic Motivations. *The Journal of Politics*, 59(3), pp.858–881.

³ Mudde, C., 2007. *Populist Radical Right Parties in Europe*. Cambridge University Press.

Indeed, the European populist radical right is characterised by nativism. This is consistent with Mudde and Kaltwasser's (2012) findings. Populism in Europe is primarily exclusionary, in particular concerning immigrants. Exclusionary populism focuses on cultural issues. The 'people' are defined using ethnic terms. This suggests that hostility to immigration is strongest towards those of different ethnic groups because they are perceived to be culturally different.

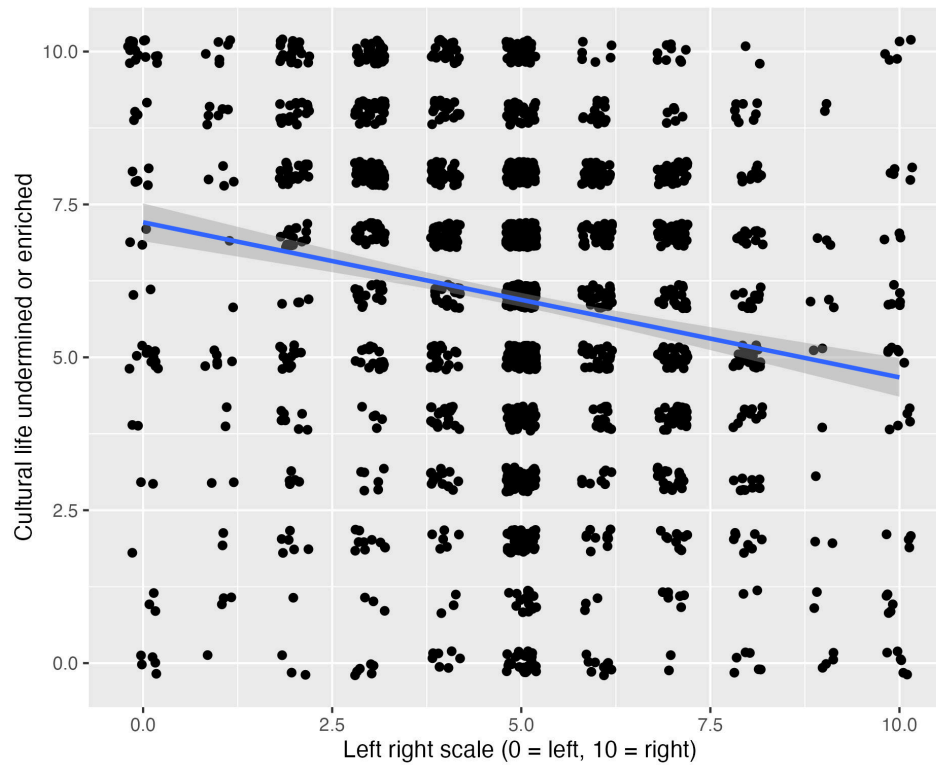
Empirical Analysis

Previous research suggests that attitudes towards immigration are strongly linked with age, education, and economic situation. People who are less-educated and have lower incomes feel greater levels of cultural and economic threat. Less-educated workers tend to reject unskilled immigrants because 'they steal our jobs'. In contrast, more years of education is associated with more positive views towards immigration. This is because university education is related to more universalistic and cosmopolitan attitudes.⁴ In contrast, fewer years of education is associated with more conservative values. While many Britons saw immigration as having negative economic and cultural effects, immigrants generally hold the opposite view.

Figure 1 confirms this relationship between ideology and immigration attitudes. There is a negative relationship. Those who are more left-wing are more likely to have positive attitudes towards immigration. A perceived threat to social conservatives' values triggered a conservative backlash. Individuals who place themselves further to the right are more likely to be hostile to immigration. Hostility to immigration is associated with the radical right. This is consistent with the cultural backlash theory.

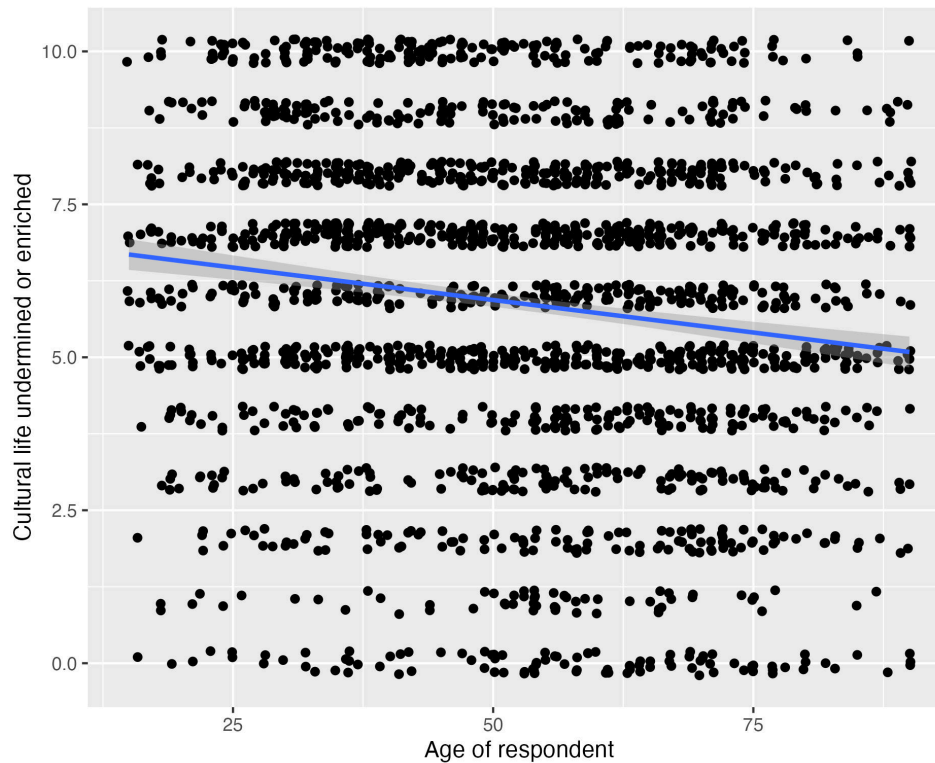
⁴ Bornschieer, S. and Kriesi, H. (2013) 'The Populist Right, the Working Class, and the Changing Face of Class Politics'. In Rydgren, J. (ed.) *Class Politics and the Radical Right*. London, Routledge, pp. 10 – 30.

Figure 1: The left-right scale and hostility to immigration



Although the relationship is weaker, figure 2 shows a similar relationship for age. Younger people are more likely to have a positive view of immigration. The silent revolution was perceived as a threat to generally older social conservatives' values, triggering a conservative backlash. Older respondents are more likely to view immigration as harmful to culture. This is because concerns about cultural change makes some older Britons feel that they are no longer living in the society in which they grew up. This relationship may also be explained by the fact that younger people are generally more educated.

Figure 2: Age and hostility to immigration



Some of the ESS's questions focused on people's views of the effects of immigration. Respondents were asked to answer the question: 'would you say that the UK's cultural life is generally undermined or enriched by people coming to live here from other countries?' They were asked to give their answer on a scale from zero to ten where zero is 'undermined' and ten is 'enriched'. Imueclt is the variable that records respondents' answers to this question. Respondents were also asked to answer the question: 'would you say it is generally bad or good for the UK's economy that people come to live here from other countries?' The scale ranged from zero to ten where zero means 'bad for the economy' and ten means 'good for the economy'. Imbgeco is the variable that records respondents' answers to this question. This allows us to distinguish between cultural and economic causes of hostility to immigration.

Table 1: Cultural and Economic Causes of Hostility to Immigration

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>	
	imueclt (1)	imbgeco (2)
lrscale	-0.208*** (0.029)	-0.146*** (0.026)
agea	-0.006* (0.003)	0.006** (0.003)
eduyrs	0.176*** (0.015)	0.151*** (0.014)
brncntr	-0.955*** (0.167)	-1.284*** (0.152)
Constant	5.595*** (0.354)	5.332*** (0.323)
Observations	1,954	1,963
R ²	0.129	0.116
Adjusted R ²	0.128	0.114
Residual Std. Error	2.448 (df = 1949)	2.228 (df = 1958)
F Statistic	72.375*** (df = 4; 1949)	64.214*** (df = 4; 1958)
<i>Note:</i> *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01		

Table 1 shows that ideology has a statistically significant effect on immigration attitudes. As we have seen, individuals who place themselves further to the right are more likely to view immigration as harmful to cultural life. The coefficient for ideology suggests that a one-unit increase on the left-right scale is associated with a 0.208 point decrease in pro-immigration attitudes concerning culture. Similarly, age has a negative effect. As we have seen, older people are more hostile to immigration. Being a year older is associated with a 0.006 point increase in hostility to immigration concerning culture. This is a smaller coefficient than for ideology. This suggests that ideology provides a stronger explanation for immigration attitudes than age. In contrast, education is associated with pro-immigration attitudes. An additional year of education is associated with a 0.176 point increase in positive attitudes to immigration concerning culture. Nevertheless, whether the respondent was born in the country has the strongest effect on attitudes to immigration. Unsurprisingly, those born outside the UK have more positive attitudes to immigration. Being born outside the country is associated with a 0.955 point decrease in hostility to immigration on cultural issues. Similarly, concerning the economy, not being born in the UK is associated with a 1.284 decrease in negative attitudes towards immigration.

The coefficient for ideology is larger concerning cultural issues (0.208) than economic issues associated with immigration (0.146). This suggests that ideology has a stronger effect on perceptions of the cultural impact than on the economic impact of immigration. Cultural factors thus seem to have a larger explanatory power for hostility to immigration. These findings support the cultural backlash theory.

Attitudes towards different types of immigration are measured using respondents' answers to two questions centred on race and ethnicity. Respondents were asked to what extent they thought the UK should allow people of the same (imsmetn) and different (imdfetn) race or ethnic group as most of the UK's people to come and live here. Possible answers were to allow many to come and live here, allow some, allow a few, or allow none. Respondents were also asked how many immigrants from poorer countries outside Europe should be allowed to come and live in their country (impctr). Consistent with the cultural backlash theory, it is expected that people will be most hostile to immigrants from poorer countries outside Europe. In contrast, it is assumed that people will be most welcoming to immigrants of the same race or ethnic group.

Table 2: Causes of Hostility to Different Types of Immigration

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	imsmetn (1)	imdfetn (2)	impctr (3)
lrscale	0.045*** (0.008)	0.050*** (0.009)	0.078*** (0.009)
agea	0.003*** (0.001)	0.005*** (0.001)	0.007*** (0.001)
eduyrs	-0.038*** (0.004)	-0.040*** (0.005)	-0.041*** (0.005)
brncntr	0.095** (0.048)	0.120** (0.051)	0.133** (0.055)
Constant	2.130*** (0.102)	2.112*** (0.108)	2.017*** (0.116)
Observations	1,938	1,951	1,951
R ²	0.075	0.090	0.119
Adjusted R ²	0.073	0.089	0.117
Residual Std. Error	0.703 (df = 1933)	0.746 (df = 1946)	0.803 (df = 1946)
F Statistic	39.309*** (df = 4; 1933)	48.403*** (df = 4; 1946)	65.797*** (df = 4; 1946)

Note:

* p<0.1; ** p<0.05; *** p<0.01

Table 2 examines attitudes towards different types of immigration. The preferred type of immigration concerns those from the same race or ethnic group as the majority. Respondents are less welcoming towards immigrants from different races or ethnic groups. Indeed, the coefficient for ideology is larger for attitudes towards immigrants from different groups (0.050) than from the same groups (0.045). Furthermore, respondents are least welcoming towards immigrants from poorer countries outside Europe. Indeed, the coefficient for ideology is the largest for attitudes towards immigrants from poorer countries outside Europe (0.078). This suggests that hostility is stronger towards immigrants who are perceived as culturally different because they are assumed to be less likely to assimilate to western values. This is consistent with the cultural backlash theory.

Conclusion

These findings suggest that hostility to immigration is best explained by cultural rather than economic concerns. Attitudes towards immigration are primarily caused by perceptions of cultural rather than economic threat. While economic explanations may explain why lower-income and less-skilled people are more hostile to immigration, evidence suggests that cultural factors have larger explanatory power. The cultural backlash theory explains why right-wing, older, less-educated Britons are more hostile to immigration. This may explain why immigration remains a prominent political issue, despite evidence that it generally has positive economic effects. Furthermore, hostility is strongest towards immigrants from different races and ethnic groups. This confirms the hypothesis that negative attitudes to immigration can be explained by concerns about cultural differences and perceived threats from ‘outsiders’.

Future research could focus on additional factors such as the use of social media, which polarises public opinion. Migrants who cross the English Channel on small boats receive intense media attention and public opposition.

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Appendix

```
install.packages("stargazer")
```

```
library(tidyverse)
```

```
library(stargazer)
```

```
ess <- read.csv("ess9_gb.csv")
```

```
setwd("~/Desktop/QStep")
```

```
model_ideology <- lm(data = ess, imueclt ~ lrscale)
```

```
summary(model_ideology)
```

```
model_age <- lm(data = ess, imueclt ~ agea)
```

```
summary(model_age)
```

```
model_education <- lm(data = ess, imueclt ~ eduyrs)
```

```
summary(model_education)
```

```
model_culture <- lm(data = ess, imueclt ~ lrscale + agea +  
eduyrs + brncntr)
```

```
summary(model_culture)
```

```
model_economy <- lm(data = ess, imbgeco ~ lrscale + agea +  
eduyrs + brncntr)
```

```
summary(model_economy)
```

```
stargazer(model_culture, model_economy, type = "text")
```

```

stargazer(model_culture,          model_economy,          out          =
"culture_and_economy_regression.html")

model_same <- lm(data = ess, imsmetn ~ lrscale + agea + eduyrs +
brncntr)
summary(model_same)

model_different <- lm(data = ess, imdfetn ~ lrscale + agea +
eduyrs + brncntr)
summary(model_different)

model_poor <- lm(data = ess, impcntr ~ lrscale + agea + eduyrs +
brncntr)
summary(model_poor)

stargazer(model_same,    model_different,    model_poor,    type    =
"text")
stargazer(model_same,    model_different,    model_poor,    out    =
"types_immigration.html")

ggplot(data = ess, aes (x = lrscale, y = imueclt)) +
  geom_jitter(width = 0.2, height = 0.2) +
  geom_smooth(method = "lm") +
  xlab("Left right scale (0 = left, 10 = right)") +
  ylab("Cultural life undermined or enriched") +
  ggtitle("Figure 1: The left-right scale and hostility to
immigration")

ggsave("lrscale plot.jpg")

ggplot(data = ess, aes (x = agea, y = imueclt)) +
  geom_jitter(width = 0.2, height = 0.2) +
  geom_smooth(method = "lm") +
  xlab("Age of respondent") +
  ylab("Cultural life undermined or enriched") +
  ggtitle("Figure 2: Age and hostility to immigration")

ggsave("agea plot.jpg")

```